Superseded as the main design (October 24, 2026). This doc was written for the earlier RTS and colony version. The Colony Sim Phase 3 doc lists which sections here still apply and how they change; anything it doesn't carry over is history only.

The Emptying — Phase 3 System Design

Oct 20, 2026 · @William

Detailed design for every system, one section per system, recorded as William decides. Numbers are starting values for balancing.

Lords

Lords are your leaders, the hero included: you start with 2 lord slots and can reach 8, and each lord holds only one job at a time. Status: first pass complete.

Titles

Title	Who or what
King or Queen	The player
Lord	Any leader, including the hero
General	A job at your stronghold: leads RTS battles and missions; stays a general until reassigned and holds no other job meanwhile
Governor	A job ruling a kept stronghold

Sources, promotion and demotion

- **Hand-made lords:** a few, enough to carry the story; more added as ideas come.
- **Promoted lords:** any colonist, at any time, for free, with randomized traits. Promotion is limited by open positions (such as foreman spots), which grow as the colony grows.
- A lord with poor leadership or skills performs poorly, and whatever they run suffers.
- **Demotion:** anyone can be demoted, hand-made lords included. It causes a morale drop, a defection risk if loyalty is low, and a heavy morale hit for hand-made lords.
- Special units and buildings come from lords, and research can add more.

Slots

Rule	Value
Starting slots	2 (the hero plus one)
Maximum slots	8
How slots grow	Stronghold or keep upgrades at set tech levels

Traits

- Every lord has 3 positive traits and 1 negative trait, like the hero.
- Traits can be anything: unit unlocks, building unlocks, battle buffs, colony bonuses, governor bonuses and more. Not every lord has a unit trait.
- Hand-made lords keep some traits the same every playthrough; others vary.
- Temperament (stern, average or lax) is separate from traits, decides how they govern, and can change over time, including from repeated battles and frequent injuries.
- **Trait transfer:** a later tech unlocks a building that can pull some traits from one person and give them to another. The donor loses the trait permanently, takes a Serious injury and may die (unkillable characters excepted). Captives and slaves can be donors, and colonists with high morality object.

Example: the retired archer

Trait	Effect	Fixed or varies
Unit	Unlocks advanced archers	Fixed
Battle	Faster unit movement	Varies
Governor	Extra tax when ruling a stronghold	Varies
Negative	His units cost more to train	Varies

In battles

- The hero plus up to 3 generals per battle, rising to 5 with tech, each commanding up to 20 soldiers.

- Generals' unit traits unlock unit types at the colony's master buildings, and their traits can work like Total War special units.
- Rival generals raise both their units' training costs by 20%. Bitter enemies refuse to deploy together.

Leveling

- Levels 1 to 20, with about +5% to stats per level.
- XP to the next level = 100 × level^1.5: about 2,000 total XP for level 10 and 6,500 for level 20.
- Trait 1 is active at recruitment, trait 2 unlocks at level 5 and trait 3 at level 10. The negative trait is active from the start. Levels 15 and 20 strengthen a trait.
- Target pace: an active lord reaches level 10 around the midpoint and 15 to 20 by the final battle.

XP source	XP
RTS battle win	300
RTS battle loss	100
Small mission	150
Dispatch mission	100
Colony job	10 per day
Training	15 per day

Stats

A lord is worth about 3 to 5 basic soldiers but can't win a battle alone.

Stat	Covers	Level 1 range
Health	Damage they can take	300–500
Attack	Personal damage	20–35
Defense	Damage reduction	5–15%
Speed	Movement	3.5–5

Stat	Covers	Level 1 range
Leadership	Buff radius and strength for nearby units	1–10
Administration	Colony job bonus, multiplying their colony trait	1–10

Injury and death

Tier	Recovery (in-game days)	Notes
Light	3	Shortened by healers and medicine
Serious	7	Result of a failed RTS battle
Critical	15	Can become permanent death if untreated

- Otherwise, lords die only through story events.
- **Permanent injuries:** a lord who takes 3 Serious or Critical injuries within 30 in-game days rolls for a permanent injury: 25% chance at Serious, 50% at Critical. Examples: a limp (-15% speed), a lost eye (-20% ranged accuracy), a crushed hand (one trait drops a tier). Some may be partly treatable with later tech.
- **The hero** is a lord in every way and can never die. While the hero is injured, the whole colony takes -15% productivity.

Governors

- A governor can be recalled. The stronghold becomes unruled: taxes fall by half and the chance it turns on you rises.

Loyalty

- Lords can defect, taking their colony bonus and some colonists close to them.
- Hand-made lords can only defect at specific story moments, though they can be demoted at any time.

Open questions

- [x] ~~A lord stays a general until reassigned. Generals are required for Final Fantasy Tactics-style dispatch missions, and their stats and traits affect the outcome.~~

Battles

Battles are fought with the colonists you bring, with no building or economy on the field, so every soldier lost is a real person from your colony. Status: first pass complete (rebuilt October 22).

The army

- The hero plus up to 3 generals (5 with tech), each commanding up to 20 soldiers. Every battle except colony defense is this size.
- You start in military tents with only the soldiers you brought, plus any rebels who join.
- No needs on the field: straight combat.
- Generals' unit traits unlock unit types at the colony's master buildings, and their traits can work like Total War special units.
- **Rebels:** come from pre-battle operations (rumors, inciting unrest). After the battle they can join the colony through your immigration rules.
- A lord knocked down is out for the rest of the battle and comes home with the matching injury. The hero going down also triggers the -15% colony productivity debuff.

The standing military

- Colonists assigned as soldiers leave their civilian jobs, eat 1.5 times as much food, train daily and are paid 3 gold per day.
- Many volunteer. You set the service terms they agree to when joining, and a draft law is available if needed.

Gear

- Soldiers own the gear they're equipped with. It comes home with them and is lost only if they die or are captured.
- Smiths repair gear and also make tools and other metal goods.

Combat

- Counters at 1.5x damage: spearmen beat cavalry, cavalry beats ranged, ranged beats infantry, siege beats buildings. Magic and race-specific units can bend these rules.

Unit	Health	Attack	Range	Speed
Militia (untrained colonist)	60	5	Melee	4.0
Spearman	90	7	Melee	4.0
Swordsman	110	9	Melee	4.0
Archer	60	6	7	4.2
Cavalry	150	10	Melee	6.5
Ram	400	40 vs buildings	Melee	2.5

- Special units from generals are about 20 to 40% stronger than these.

Winning, losing and retreating

Outcome	Condition
Win (small battles)	Kill every enemy unit
Win (strongholds)	Kill every enemy unit and sack the stronghold's main building
Lose	Your whole army is destroyed
Retreat	Allowed any time. Counts as a loss, but injuries are one tier lighter

- If the hero and every lord are knocked down, every soldier still fighting takes -30 morale, but the fight goes on.
- After a loss, only a handful of soldiers come home with you and your lords. Each returning soldier loses 15 opinion of the ruler, and the whole colony loses 5 as word spreads.

The enemy

- Strongholds have a fixed garrison plus reinforcement waves on a timer.

Difficulty	First wave	Time between waves	Wave growth	Wave cap
Easy	8 min	5 min	+2 units	15 units
Normal	6 min	4 min	+3 units	25 units
Hard	4 min	3 min	+4 units	40 units

Softening a target first

Dispatch missions before a battle can thin the garrison or delay waves. Success depends on the general's stats and traits, and every operation has a downside, even on success.

Operation	On success	Downside or on failure
Necromancer's havoc	Enemy loses workers and units	You face an undead horde too
Poison the king	Enemy leadership buffs gone	Enemy raises defenses
Sabotage stores	Enemy starts weaker	General captured on failure
Assassinate a general	Enemy loses a unit type	Faction relations drop sharply
Spread rumors	Some enemy units defect to you	Enemy grows suspicious; the next operation has a lower chance

Maps and vision

- Age of Empires-style fog of war.
- Stronghold maps are hand-made; small sites are procedurally generated.
- Retaking a lost keep happens on the same map, with some random elements; a place left to decline is more run-down.

After a battle

- You choose: leave, claim or destroy.

- **Loot:** after a win, you take what the army can carry, about 10 gold or materials per soldier, more with wagons from research. Claiming a keep gives you its stockpile instead.
- Only keeps can be claimed; small sites can't.

Claimed keeps

- Claiming costs 2,000 gold and the keep starts with nothing.
- You send your own settlers: volunteers, or forced if no one volunteers. You can also send supplies to get the town going.
- The army that took it must stay until the settlers arrive.
- It needs a window of safety at the start so the player can get it in order.
- About 15 buildings at most, a bit like Riftbreaker. A share of production is sent home through trade routes, and you appoint a governor.
- It follows all of your main colony's laws, enforced by the governor (honestly, one hopes).

Combat core

Shared rules for colony defense, small missions and battles: soldiers fight to the death, Age of Empires-style, and the cost shows up afterward in deaths, trauma and grief. Status: first pass complete.

Damage and armor

- Damage = attack × counter multiplier (1.5 or 1.0) × (1 − armor reduction), with ±10% randomness.
- Armor reduction runs from 0% (cloth) to about 50% (heavy plate).
- Each armor piece has a weight. A soldier's speed drops 5% for each weight point above their strength allowance, which comes from Melee skill and traits.
- Colonists placed on active duty or joining the military automatically take the best armor available for them; if only heavy armor is in stock, they take it.

Morale

- Soldiers don't rout: they fight to the death if needed.
- Low morale lowers stats: below 50, -10% attack and defense; below 25, -25%.

- A soldier who sees a comrade die next to them is affected by it.
- After battle, soldiers may defect or develop lasting trauma.
- Losses carry home: a soldier's death hits their spouse and friends through grief.

Formations

Formation	Effect
Line	+10% defense against frontal attacks
Column	Moves faster
Loose	Takes less damage from ranged attacks

Downed soldiers

- In battle, units simply die. The after-battle report then does the math on who actually survived: to the player, the fallen were knocked down or wounded until the report says otherwise.
- Survival starts at a 35% base, scaled by your power compared with the enemy's at the start of the battle:

Your power vs. theirs	Multiplier	Base survival
Under 80%	×0.5	About 17%
80–120%	×1.0	35%
120–200%	×1.5	About 52%
Over 200%	×2.0	70%

- Then: +15% if a medic reached them, up to +20% from armor quality, and -20% if the killing blow was far beyond their remaining health.
- Survivors take an injury on the lord injury tiers. After a loss or retreat, survivors left on the field are captured instead of coming home.
- The same math decides how many fallen enemies survive; those become your possible captives.

Trauma

- Each nearby death a soldier sees adds 10% trauma chance; a lost battle adds 15%.
- Trauma is a lasting negative trait (nightmares, jumpiness, -5 mood) that a doctor or priest can treat over 20 to 40 days.
- Badly traumatized soldiers ask to leave the military.

Medics

- Colonists with Medicine skill can join as medics. They stay at the back and stabilize downed soldiers nearby, improving their survival chance.
- Medics carry only a dagger but can fight if needed. There are no guns in this game.

Colony defense

- Same rules, plus towers and walls, the whole standing military and any drafted colonists.
- Civilians flee to shelters you build; anyone caught outside can be hurt or killed. Shelters and alarm bells are useful buildings.

Game data

All content is data, not code, so items, units and everything else can be added or removed easily, in the spirit of Unity's ScriptableObjects. Status: first pass complete.

- **Everything as data:** resources, items, units, buildings, traits, laws, rules, crimes, faiths, events, techs, relics, factions, sub-factions, dialogue and the relic's paired lines. Code only runs the systems.
- **Format:** human-readable, version-controlled data files in the project folder. The exact format follows the engine chosen in Phase 4.
- **Intake:** a large database authored in spreadsheets. Fill in a row (for a resource: name, category, base price, spoil time, stack size, races who like it, what produces it, what uses it), and a converter script turns the sheet into game data and checks for mistakes. The same approach covers items, units, traits and other content.
- **Validation:** data is checked on load and problems are reported clearly instead of crashing or failing silently.
- **Permanent IDs:** every piece of content has an ID that never changes, even if its name does. Saves reference IDs, so renaming content doesn't break old saves.

- **Text:** all player-facing text, including the relic's surface and true lines, lives in separate text files from the start, so translation needs no code changes.
- **Mods:** players can mod the game by adding data files.

Saves

Normal mode allows manual saves plus rotating autosaves; ironman keeps one autosave with no reloading. Saves are local only. Status: first pass complete.

	Normal	Ironman
Manual saves	Unlimited, grouped by playthrough (a folder per ruler)	None
Autosaves	Last 5 rotate	One file, overwritten
Quitting	Normal	Saves automatically
After the ending	Earlier saves stay usable	Save locked as completed, viewable as a history (ruler, key events, epilogue)

- **Autosave timing:** every in-game day at dawn, and before and after every battle, mission launch, travel and major story event.
- **Contents:** everything the simulation tracks, including every colonist's needs, traits, relationships, preferences, morality, opinion, money and home; buildings and staff; laws, rules, standings, research, relics, keeps, outposts, spies, scouts and pending events.
- Files are compressed. A 300-colonist colony should be a few megabytes and save in under 2 seconds.
- **Version safety:** old saves load after updates. Removed content is dropped or replaced with a fallback, and the player sees a warning listing what changed.
- Local saves only; no cloud saves for now.

UI

The interface is built to manage a colony of up to about 500 people, with an advisor who forecasts outcomes and tooltips that explain every number. Status: first pass complete.

Main screens

Screen	Purpose
Colony view	The main map with a top bar (resources, gold, date, speed) and a selected-object panel
Colonist panel	One person: needs, mood and its causes, traits, skills, preferences, relationships, morality, opinion, money, home
Lords	Roster, jobs, traits, levels, injuries, loyalty
Laws and rules	Two tabs, showing who likes or dislikes each setting before you change it
Research	Tabs by branch, plus relic and diplomatic trees
War room	Overworld map, missions, scouts, spies, keeps, outposts
Diplomacy	Standings, ripple previews, sub-factions, embassy
Economy	Treasury, wages, taxes, stock, businesses, zone revenue
Reports	Away reports, battle reports, event history

The advisor

- An advisor role shows the likely outcome of choices before you commit: who a law will upset, how an attack ripples to other kingdoms, the morality cost of an execution.
- Without a good advisor, these forecasts are less accurate.

Finding information

- **Overlays** on the colony map: mood, wealth, race, faith, crime, zones, building quality and defense range.
- **Alerts** stack on one side, color-coded by urgency. Clicking one jumps to it; kinds can be filtered; critical ones can auto-pause.
- **Tooltips everywhere:** hovering over any number explains where it comes from.
- **Colonist list:** searchable and sortable by job, mood, skill, race, faith and wealth, with bulk actions. The colony should support up to about 500 people and feel big.

Accessibility

- Rebindable keys (required), text scaling and a colorblind-safe palette for overlays and alerts.

Camera and controls

Age of Empires-style camera and standard RTS controls, the same in the colony and in battle. Status: first pass complete.

- **Camera:** tilted top-down; pan, zoom (from close enough to see faces to a wide district view) and rotate.
- **Controls:** left-click to select, drag to box-select, right-click to command, number keys for control groups, space to pause, 1 to 3 for speed. All rebindable.
- **Direct control:** only combat-ready colonists are commanded like RTS units. Civilians can't be ordered directly; you influence them through jobs, priorities, laws and praise.

Audio

Music and sound reflect the colony's state and the relic's growing hold. Status: first pass complete.

- **Music:** dynamic. Calm when things are good, tense during crises and battles, darker as the relic's influence grows, so the soundtrack foreshadows the ending.
- **Sound:** the colony sounds alive (distant hammering, market crowds, temple prayers). A quiet colony sounds empty, which is a cue in itself.
- **Voice:** text only for now. When voice is added as polish, the relic gets it first, so the reveal can change its voice audibly.

Small missions

- They Are Billions-style: a general and a few soldiers, using the same stats and counters.

Removed in the rebuild

- Starting setups (Under, Normal, Over), gathering, workers by race, battle buildings, militia training, the population cap, turtling inside battles and the settlers' loot share.
- Loot rules after a battle are still to be decided.

Colonist simulation

Colonists run on needs, race-specific wants and detailed personal preferences that combine into a mood from 0 to 100, which drives their work and their risk of breaking. Status: first pass complete.

Needs

Each need runs from 0 to 100 and decays over time. Colonists eat, so the colony needs a food chain.

Need	Empties in about	Filled by
Hunger	1 day	Meals
Rest	1.5 days	Sleep; better beds help
Comfort	3 days	Furniture, room quality
Recreation	3 days	Leisure buildings, social time
Social	2 days	Talking, friends, partners
Safety	Event-driven	Defenses, guards, no recent attacks
Faith	4 days	Worship, matching religion

Race needs and wants

Race	Unique need
Humans	Community: both crowding and isolation hurt
Creatures	Blood or raw meat
Demons	Heat or suffering: forges, punishment, harsh laws

- Each race also wants different food, a different part of the map to live in, and more.
- Colonists have detailed individual preferences on top of their race's.

Mood

Mood comes from needs plus temporary thoughts (a friend died, a good meal, an execution witnessed), each with a value and a duration.

Mood	Range	Effect on work
Breaking	0–14	Mental break risk
Unhappy	15–34	-15%
Content	35–64	Normal
Happy	65–84	+10%
Inspired	85–100	+20%, chance of a special boost

Mental breaks

Tier	Examples
Minor	Wandering, binge-eating, refusing work
Major	Fights, sabotage, theft
Extreme	Murder, arson, deserting to another faction

- Morality and traits affect which kind a colonist leans toward.
- A colonist in a mental break can't be made to fight.

Traits

- Regular colonists have 1 to 3 traits, any mix of good and bad (for example Hard Worker, Night Owl, Bloodthirsty, Pious, Lazy).

Preferences

Every colonist has 4 to 6 preferences, partly from their race and partly personal. Race preferences are visible at once; personal ones reveal over the first few days.

Category	Example	Met	Violated
Favorite food	Roast boar	+6 mood for 1 day	None
Hated food	Fish	None	-6 for 1 day
Home area	Near forest, forge or water	+5 ongoing	-5 ongoing
Preferred job	Smithing	+4 while doing it	-4 if forced into a hated job
Room	Private room, shared bunk, dark room	+3 to +8	-3 to -8
Company	Likes or dislikes certain races or traits	+3 per liked neighbor	-3 per disliked neighbor
Faith	Their religion	+5 with a matching worship site	-8 if it's banned

Race home areas: the colony map has zones such as forest, open fields, rocky ground, water, and possibly volcanic or blighted ground. Humans prefer fields and water, creatures prefer forest and darkness, demons prefer rocky or volcanic heat. Where you build housing is a racial politics decision.

Schedules

- Days are split into hour blocks: sleep, work, recreation, training, worship.
- Fully editable by the player, per colonist or by group.
- A manager can set schedules by policy instead: fixed hours (such as 9 to 5), night shifts, or each person's own preferences.
- Preference-based schedules work well in a mixed colony, where different sleep patterns cover every hour, but some people may end up working less.
- A foreman can push people to work harder.

Life cycle

- Couples can have children. Colonists age and can die of old age.
- Children become working teens in 20 days and adults in 40 days, so they matter within one playthrough.

- Only humans age: 1 year per 60-day in-game year. Humans are old at 60 and die around 70 to 80. Other races don't age.

Time scale

Measure	Value
One in-game day	About 12 real minutes at normal speed
Season	15 days
Year	60 days (4 seasons)
Rush playthrough (about 30 hours)	Roughly 120 to 150 days
Colony-focused playthrough (100+ hours)	Roughly 500 days or more

A 30-hour run is the rush pace. Players who invest in the colony can play well past 100 hours.

Skills

Each skill runs 0 to 20 and improves by doing the work. A colonist can have an interest in a skill: faster learning and a mood boost while doing it.

Group	Skills
Labor	Construction, Mining, Logging, Hauling
Food	Farming, Hunting, Cooking
Craft	Crafting, Smithing, Tailoring
Mind	Medicine, Research, Magic
People	Social (trade, diplomacy), Administration
Combat	Melee, Ranged

Work speed = 50% + 5% per skill level: skill 0 is half speed, skill 10 normal, skill 20 is 150%.

Jobs

Buildings have up to 3 job slots; some, especially early-game buildings, have only 1.

Slot	Effect
Worker	Does the building's job at their skill speed
Manager	Changes all workers' output from -20% to +25%, based on Administration
Trainer	Workers in that building learn 50% faster

- Work outside buildings (hauling, cleaning, construction, firefighting) uses RimWorld-style priorities from 1 to 4, which unassigned colonists follow automatically.
- A foreman ordering people to work harder gives +15% output and an "overworked" thought of -8 mood while active.

Relationships

Every pair of colonists who know each other has an opinion score from -100 to +100, built from shared traits, race attitudes, preferences and events.

Score	Relationship
-100 to -60	Enemy (may fight or sabotage)
-59 to -20	Rival
-19 to +19	Acquaintance
+20 to +59	Friend
+60 to +100	Close friend, or partner if romance occurs

- **Romance** starts only between friends at +40 or higher. Couples date, move in together, can marry and have children. Mixed-race couples are possible.
- A breakup causes a large mood hit and an opinion drop. Relationships can also turn abusive.
- **Reproduction differs by race:** some races don't have children. See the table below.

Race	How new members appear	Catch	Ways around it
Humans	Children with a partner	Children can't work for 20 days	None needed
Vampires	Turning another colonist	Turning an unwilling person is a dark act; morality and the victim's friends react	Some humans want to become vampires
Werewolves	Infecting another colonist	Risk of an uncontrolled first transformation	None yet
Demons	Spawning, which needs a resource such as suffering or souls	Feeds on the colony's dark side	Buy slaves, make slaves, or free prisoners found in some RTS battles, Bannerlord-style

- **Abuse:** the abused partner's mood drops steadily and the abuser carries a hidden flag. After the right tech, a special doctor or detective can find it: a report flags something like bruises, and you dispatch the detective at a cost. Discovery triggers your crime laws. No explicit depiction.
- **Werewolf infection:** a group sent on an interface-based mission can come back infected. On a full moon they transform and go berserk. Creatures have their own animations where they differ from humans.

Race attitudes

- Each colonist starts with an attitude toward every other race, from hostile to friendly, based on race and traits.
- Living and working together and events shift it slowly. Some colonists adapt well; others don't.
- New arrivals never kill over race hatred alone. Killings can happen later, when a personal conflict escalates.

Death and grief

Relationship to the dead	Mood hit	Duration
Partner	-20	10 days
Close friend	-12	5 days
Friend	-6	3 days

- The colony needs a graveyard. Without one, people grow sad and plague can break out.

Blocs

- A bloc forms when 5 or more colonists share a strong trait, race or faith, such as a demon bloc or a pious bloc.
- Blocs have demands, such as "legalize blood feeding" or "ban slavery." Meeting them gives the bloc a mood boost.
- Ignored demands escalate: petitions, then protests (work slowdowns), then strikes, and at the extreme the whole bloc leaves together.
- Blocs decorate the areas they live in.
- Each bloc is led by its most influential member, who can be promoted to lord to win the bloc over, or jailed to break it.

Morality

Each colonist has a morality value from -100 (ruthless) to +100 (principled), set by race, traits and religion and shifted by what they witness and take part in.

Act	Weight
Freeing slaves, mercy to prisoners	+15
Fair trial	+5
Harsh punishment	-10
Execution	-15
Taking slaves	-20

Act	Weight
Turning an unwilling person, trait extraction	-25
The midpoint sacrifice	-40

A colonist reacts when an act's weight is more than 30 points from their own morality.

Distance	Reaction
30–50	Mood hit
50–80	Mood hit and opinion of the ruler drops
80+	Chance to leave or defect

- **Witnessing:** seen acts hit at full strength, rumors (spreading over a couple of days) at half, and secret acts done through a trusted lord can stay hidden, at a risk of discovery.
- **Crimes in front of others:** some witnesses try to stop a murder, others run. Witnesses count as evidence, so executing a murderer with evidence hits morale less hard.
- **Drift:** living in a dark colony pulls colonists darker by about 1 point per 10 days, down to a floor set by traits. A Pious or Kind colonist never drops below +20.

Opinion of the ruler

- Each colonist has an opinion of the King or Queen from -100 to +100, separate from morality, built from your acts, how their needs are met, and laws they like or hate.
- Below -50, they are a desertion or rebellion risk.

Laws, crime and justice

The ruler sets rules (kingdom management settings that don't personally affect colonists) and laws (settings that do), in categories; crimes are caught through witnesses, guards and detectives, and the warden enforces your rules with their own judgment while you're away. Laws, crimes and punishments are all defined as data. Status: first pass complete.

Rules and laws

	Rules	Laws
What they are	Kingdom management settings	Settings that affect people
Mood and opinion effects	None	Yes, with likes and dislikes
Flip-flop penalty	None	Yes
Examples	Immigration (open, closed, vetting criteria), business caps, business approval criteria and license fees, government store prices, trade settings, stockpile and hauling priorities, research queue, outpost upgrade priorities, which lord owns which task	Punishments, trials, executions, taxes, wages, land tax, work hours, race standing, slavery and private slave ownership, captive treatment, religion, blood feeding and turning, marriage rules, curfews, alcohol, dueling

- Immigrants always arrive single; no families come.
- Immigration checks trade speed for safety: deep checks slow arrivals but catch more (including spies later in the game); fast checks let almost anyone in.

Law categories

A starting set; each setting pleases some blocs and races, angers others, and some affect productivity.

Category	Settings
Punishment	Lenient, Standard, Harsh, Brutal
Work hours	Light, Standard, Long
Race standing	Equal, Tiered (a favored race), Segregated
Captives	Release, Imprison, Forced labor, Enslave
Slavery	Banned, Legal, Encouraged
Religion	Free, State religion, Banned faiths

Category	Settings
Blood feeding	Banned, Consenting only, Captives and slaves allowed
Executions	Banned, For murder only, At the ruler's will

- Each law setting carries likes and dislikes per race, faith and trait, stored as data. Example: Slavery: Encouraged pleases demons and Ruthless colonists and angers humans with high morality. Blocs form their demands from these dislikes.
- **Changing a law:** colonists who dislike the new setting get -5 mood for 3 days; those who like it get +5 for 3 days.
- **Flip-flopping:** reversing a law within 15 days of changing it costs every colonist -10 opinion of the ruler and doubles the unrest. Each further reversal in that window stacks another -5.
- **Work hours:** Long gives +15% output and -6 mood; Light gives -10% output and +4 mood.
- **Segregation** halves cross-race conflict but freezes race attitudes so they never improve.
- **Vetted immigration:** up to 3 conditions, such as a minimum skill, an allowed race, no criminal history or a required faith. Turned-away immigrants can be taken as slaves or sacrifices; otherwise they sometimes return as raiders or spread word that lowers your standing with their race.

Crimes

Tier	Crimes
Minor	Theft, vandalism, brawling, skipping work
Serious	Assault, sabotage, abuse, illegal feeding or turning, heresy (if a faith is banned)
Grave	Murder, arson, desertion to an enemy, treason

- **Detection:** witnesses, guard patrols, or the detective (after tech). An unwitnessed crime has a 30% base chance of discovery within 3 days, raised by guards and the warden's Administration.

Trials and punishment

- **Trial:** takes 1 day, counts as a fair trial (+5 morality) and can acquit the innocent.
- **Direct judgment:** instant, no morality bonus.
- The warden uses whichever the law sets.

Punishment	Morality weight
Fine	0
Labor duty (days)	-2
Jail (days)	-3
Flogging	-10
Banishment	-8
Enslavement	-20
Execution	-15, or -5 with evidence

Jail

- A prison building with cells, which needs a guard.
- Prisoners have needs and eat food.
- Escape chance rises with too few guards or low prisoner mood.

The warden

- Follows your rules but uses judgment within them. Where a law allows a range (Harsh allows jail through flogging), a stern warden picks the top and a lax warden the bottom. They never go outside your law.
- You can overrule a warden's call, at a cost to their opinion of you.
- Crimes still happen while you're away; the warden handles them, and everything appears in the away report.

Colony economy

The colony runs on raw, processed and finished goods in chains of at most 3 steps, with food spoilage, race-specific meals, blood and suffering shaping how each race is kept. Status: first pass complete.

Resources

Layer	Resources
Raw	Wood, stone, iron ore, gold, clay, grain, vegetables, meat, fish, herbs, fiber, hides, blood
Processed	Planks, bricks, iron bars, steel, cloth, leather, meals, medicine
Finished	Weapons, armor, furniture, tools, luxuries (ale, wine, jewelry)
Special	Essence (magic material), suffering (demon resource)

- Production chains are at most 3 steps, such as iron ore to bars to a sword.
- Adding new resources must be easy: a data intake system, designed in detail with the game data system.

Storage and spoilage

Item	Spoils in
Blood	2 days
Raw meat	3 days
Grain	30 days

- Stockpile zones and warehouses. Cold storage (from tech) prevents spoilage.
- Blood's short life means creature colonies need a steady supply, not stockpiles.

Meals

Cooked separately for each race's diet.

Meal	Mood	Requirement
Simple	0	Any cook
Fine	+4	Cooking 8+
Lavish	+8	Cooking 14+ and luxury ingredients

- Eating another race's food: -3 mood. Eating raw food: -6 and a sickness risk, except for creatures, who prefer it.

Blood

Source	Notes
Livestock	Lowest quality
Willing donors	Lose some health and rest
Captives or slaves	A dark act, but the most efficient

- A blood house stores and preserves it.

Suffering

- An invisible colony-wide meter, not a stockpile. It fills from prisoners, slaves, punishments, harsh laws and mental breaks.
- Demons draw on it to spawn and to meet their unique need, so a happy, fair colony starves its demons.
- A whole set of buildings will focus on it. A separate demonic energy resource is possible.

Gold

- Sources: mining, taxes from kept strongholds, taxes on your own colonists (with an opinion cost), trade, and selling goods or slaves.
- Spent on claiming keeps, trade, detectives, hiring and diplomacy gifts.

Starting state

- After the funeral: around 6 to 8 loyal followers, some food and building materials, a decaying keep and very little gold. The early game is about making the colony work, not fighting.

Threat scaling

- Random attacks scale with colony wealth and tech level. Story attacks are fixed.

Attack strength = colony wealth ÷ 100 + techs researched × 10, with a floor so early raids are never trivial and a cap per difficulty. A wealth screen shows how much danger your riches attract.

Outposts

- Resources on the colony map can run out over a long game. Small points of interest with resources can become outposts.
- An outpost isn't a battle: you send settlers and guards through a menu, and those people leave the colony. It's managed entirely through the interface.
- It sends a fixed amount each day (a mine sends 40 ore), arriving after a delay based on distance.
- Three upgrade levels, paid in gold and materials: 100%, 150% and 200% output.
- Factions never retake outposts. A bandit raid event can pause deliveries for a few days unless you send a small mission to clear it.

Depletion

- Wood regrows and farms never run out.
- Ore, stone and clay deposits are finite, holding 1,500 to 3,000 units each. Deep mining tech can find more later.

Demonic energy

- Suffering is the invisible meter. Special buildings, such as a pain altar or a soul furnace, convert it into demonic energy, a real stockpile.
- Demonic energy is spent on spawning demons, demon tech and dark magic.

Colony taxes

Rate	Share of wages	Opinion of the ruler
None	0%	0
Low	10%	-3
Medium	20%	-8
High	35%	-15

Wages and personal wealth

Colonists earn and spend their own gold, build their own homes in zones you set, and can open their own businesses, so much of the colony's growth happens without you.

Personal money

- Every colonist arrives with a random amount of gold.
- Gold is a personal goal. Left unmanaged, colonists work to earn it, even at jobs they don't love.
- Admitted colonists with no job get a basic stipend: enough to live on, not enough for a house.
- A small chance exists that a colonist has no ambition and lives as a beggar.
- Each colonist has a **greed** value (chases the best pay) and an **ambition** value (may start a business). Unassigned colonists choose work by balancing pay, preference and skill.
- Unpaid colonists get -10 mood and lose opinion of the ruler each day. After 5 unpaid days, they may strike or leave.

Government buildings

- You build, fund and staff them. You pay the workers and keep all profit.
- They are generic and basic: a boarding house holds many people but is unpleasant; a government store sells only the cheapest food.
- The government handles basic goods such as wood and ore, so private businesses don't compete with it on raw materials.

Job type	Wage per day
Unskilled (hauling, logging)	2 gold
Skilled (smithing, cooking)	4 gold
Expert (medicine, research)	6 gold
Lords	10 gold
Stipend (no job)	1 gold

Zoning and private homes

- Only the King or Queen can establish zones, but you can assign a lord to run each zone.
- Colonists save up, buy the resources, build their own homes and then owe land taxes.
- Each zone caps how far a home can be upgraded. To move up, a colonist sells their home (to the government for a low price, or to another colonist) and moves to a better zone.
- Homes visibly reflect their owner's wealth.

Zone	Land tax per day	Home cap	Who it suits
Low	1 gold	Shack to cottage	Laborers, new arrivals
Middle	3 gold	Up to a townhouse	Skilled workers
High	6 gold	Up to a manor	Experts, merchants, lords

- **Corruption:** a zone's lord can lie and keep more of the taxes. If you notice revenue dropping, you can send a tax auditor to investigate.

Corruption and audits

- Every lord has a hidden honesty value, revealed over time. Dishonest lords skim 5 to 25% of what they handle, depending on honesty and greed.
- Anything a lord job handles in money can be skimmed: zone taxes, business license fees, governor income from strongholds, the treasury.
- **Tax auditor:** a job or dispatch task for a colonist with high Administration. An audit takes 2 days and finds skimming with a 40% chance plus 3% per Administration point. A failed audit warns the lord, who skims less for a while, or flees if loyalty is low.

- Embezzlement is handled by whatever laws the ruler sets. Other lords notice how you respond.

Private businesses

- Colonists with high ambition and savings covering the building plus a license fee (set by you) can open a business on a free plot in a commercial zone. Example: a blacksmith.
- They pay a 15% profit tax and keep the rest.
- **Approval:** micromanage from a list of applicants, or delegate to a lord who owns that task and approves only those meeting your criteria (for example: no convicted criminals; tax rate X%).
- **Need-based:** colonists only open a type of business the colony is short of. The first fills the need; more may follow for competition, up to a cap per business type that the ruler sets (default 3). Raising it lets the colony overproduce a good, such as swords to trade for clothes.
- Businesses buy materials from the colony stockpile at market price, hire unemployed colonists at their own wages, and set prices within ±20% of base.
- A business that loses money for 10 days goes bankrupt; the building is sold to the government at a low price.
- **Seizing:** the ruler can seize a business, then auction it or destroy it. Ambitious colonists take a big opinion hit, everyone else a smaller one.

Prices

- Every item has a fixed base price in the game data. Government stores sell at a price you set; private stores within ±20%. Prices don't fluctuate with supply and demand.

Slaves and prisoners

- Earn nothing. The government provides for state-owned slaves.
- Colonists can own slaves privately if the ruler allows it.
- The ruler can create taxes related to slaves, which can anger some people.

Research and tech

Research is a large system spread across several tabs, run by scholars and specialists, and it keeps running while you're away. Status: first pass complete.

Tabs

Tab	Covers
Kingdom	Buildings, economy, storage, outposts, deep mining
Military	Units, defenses (wood to stone to reinforced), siege, more general slots
Society	Laws, detective, auditor, trait transfer, religion buildings
Medicine	Healing, cold storage, plague control, treating permanent injuries
Race	Human, Cursed and demon research, opened three ways: the embassy teaches the leaning of the kingdom you're aligned with; allying with a sub-faction opens a small, limited tech path for that group; studying creatures gives smaller gains: each creature type has a study track (faster with a captive, slower with a body), each of 3 stages gives +10% damage against that type, and the last stage reveals a weakness, such as silver against werewolves
Diplomatic	Up to 5 techs per faction you align with, unlocking larger or global effects. They unlock in order as standing rises and are kept after an alliance ends
Relic	Finding a relic instantly opens its own research tree, which unlocks its own building. That building then demands whatever the relic requires, such as sacrifices, gold or wood

- Having creatures in the colony isn't enough: a colony full of demons gets no demon tech without one of those routes. This stops players from collecting every benefit and adds replay value.
- If an alliance ends, that kingdom leaves the embassy and its tree goes dark. Techs already researched are kept, so they are designed not to rely on staying aligned.

Progression and unlocks

- **Traversal techs gate the map,** Castlevania-style, but through research instead of gear: crossing large waters (no ships or naval warfare), climbing gear to reach a mountain kingdom, and similar.
- These are mostly the starting techs of each tab, so a focused player can move faster. Most of the rest is improvements such as upgraded homes.
- **Context-based trees:** a tree opens when the colony gains the right person. With no blacksmith at the start, the smithing tree opens once you find one or one opens a business, and it stays open even if they leave.
- Research can cost more than time, such as making 200 swords to unlock a better sword.
- Unlocks are never tied to an individual: replacing a blacksmith changes nothing.

Kingdom	Example diplomatic techs
Pure human kingdom	Royal charter (+1 lord slot), trade guild (better prices)
Cursed kingdom	Blood pact (vampire turning without moral cost on willing humans), night sight (units see in darkness)
Demon kingdom	Infernal contract (demonic energy from fewer sources), hellfire (fire damage on siege)

Research speed

- Scholars at research buildings (a study, later a library and an academy) produce research points using the work speed formula. One average scholar makes about 10 points per day.
- Some research, such as relics, needs specialists.

Cost band	Cost per tech	Number of techs
1	100–200	About 12
2	300–600	About 12
3	800–1,500	About 12

Cost band	Cost per tech	Number of techs
4	2,000–4,000	About 10
5	5,000–8,000	About 8

- Cost bands are a guide to how expensive early, mid and late techs are, not unlock rules.

Spies

- A spy is one of your colonists, sent to live in another kingdom's city. You lose them from the colony while they're there.
- Kingdoms change as events happen, but you only learn about it if you have a spy in that city.
- Spies level up and can perform any action up to their level. The chance of getting caught rises with each action, not just with time.

Spy level	Unlocks
1	Report kingdom events
2	Report army strength before battles
3	Steal technology (failure costs relations heavily)
4	Sabotage, incite unrest
5	Assassinate

- **Captured spies:** a faction may offer them back for gold, a technology or a captive. Refuse, and the spy is executed; colonists close to them react.
- **Enemy spies:** later in the game, other kingdoms send spies disguised as ordinary immigrants with a hidden flag. Vetting, the warden, guards and the detective can catch them. Uncaught, they steal tech, report your defenses (strengthening attacks on you) or sabotage.

Faction relationships and diplomacy

Each faction has one standing value with you, ripples spread every change to the others, and a growing minimum gap keeps any two from ever being equal. Status: first pass complete.

Kingdoms and sub-factions

Every kingdom is human (changed October 22). Creatures and demons are sub-factions: still encountered, still able to join your colony, and favored by some kingdoms.

Kingdom	Leaning	Flavor	Home region
The large kingdom (those who left you)	Pure human	Order, faith, distrusts the supernatural	Human heartland
A second kingdom	The Cursed	Nobles who keep vampires, blood courts	Creature wilds
A third kingdom	Demons	Sorcerers who bargain with demons	Demon wastes

- **Sub-factions** (vampire covens, werewolf packs, demon cults and others) have their own standing and diplomacy on the same -100 to +100 scale.
- The never-equal rule covers only the three kingdoms. You never fully ally with sub-factions, so you can be friendly with many at once.
- At Friendly, a sub-faction sends occasional recruits. At Allied, it opens its small tech path and sends a handful of fighters to the final battle.
- Sub-factions never abandon you in the final war, though they don't provide much.
- There is a single, multi-faction embassy.

Standing

Standing	Range	Means
Hostile	-100 to -50	Attacks you, no trade
Unfriendly	-49 to -10	Raids, poor trade prices
Neutral	-9 to +9	Trade at normal prices

Standing	Range	Means
Friendly	+10 to +49	First perk, better prices
Allied	+50 to +100	Alignment possible, embassy, diplomatic tab

Never equal

- A minimum gap always separates your standings with any two factions. If an action would close it, the faction you acted on least recently slips down to keep the gap.
- The gap grows with the story: 5 points early, 15 after the midpoint, 30 in the late game. Early on you can be friends with everyone; over time the game forces favorites.

Ripples

When your standing with one faction changes, the others shift by half that amount, scaled by their attitude toward it. Example: attacking the Cursed kingdom (-30) gives the pure human kingdom +9 and the demon kingdom +3.

Pair	Attitude
Pure human kingdom and Cursed kingdom	-60
Pure human kingdom and demon kingdom	-40
Cursed kingdom and demon kingdom	-20

What moves standing

Action	Change
Gift of gold	+1 per 100 gold, weaker with each repeat
Trade deal	+1 per trade
Favor or quest	+5 to +15
Lord marriage	+20, once per faction
Taking in their refugees	+3
Enslaving their people	-5 per person

Action	Change
Spy caught	-15
Attacking a stronghold	-40

Ally perks

- 1 perk at Friendly, 2 more at Allied, all lost if standing drops below that level.
- Example: humans give +10% build speed at Friendly, then cheaper wages and +1 trade caravan at Allied.

Ambassadors

- Each embassy needs a lord in the Ambassador job. Their Social skill speeds standing gains with that faction by up to 50%, and their traits can help or hurt.

The hero's marriage

- The hero can marry, but only within their own kingdom. It's a status, not a diplomatic tool.
- The hero and their spouse are both tied to the relic, don't age and can't have children.

Lord marriages

- Lords can be married into other factions for +20 standing, once per faction.
- You can force a lord to marry against their preferences (race attitudes, an existing partner). Forcing it carries a -10 morality weight and costs the lord's opinion of you.

Over time

- **Midpoint drift:** after the relic mission and its sacrifice, the minimum gap jumps to 15, and every faction cools toward you by 1 point per 5 days. The faction you're closest to cools at half that rate. Alliances must be maintained in the second half.
- **Raids:** Unfriendly factions raid about every 20 days, Hostile ones about every 10. Size follows the threat formula. No raids while you're away.

Alignment

- You can be aligned with only one faction at a time.

- Switching closes the old embassy (its tree goes dark), costs -30 standing with the old ally, and requires building the new embassy.

Trade caravans

- Neutral or better factions send a caravan every 15 days; Allied factions every 7.
- Caravans carry race-specific goods that are hard to make, such as blood from creatures or demon-forged metal, and also slaves.

The final battle

- Each faction's force = base strength minus 15% per completed side mission in its region, down to 40%.
- Your closest faction withdraws completely.

Story, relics and events

The story runs in three acts advanced only by story missions, the relic speaks every line with a hidden true meaning, and a storyteller fires events every few days. Status: first pass complete.

Acts

Act	Covers	Ends with
1: Rebuild	Funeral, rebuilding, first alliances, the relic as trusted guide	First stronghold taken
2: Rise	Strongholds, relics, alliances at their peak	The midpoint relic mission and sacrifice
3: The Turn	Drift, factions turning, preparing for the end	The final battle and the Emptying

- Acts advance through story missions, never time, so a player can stay in any act as long as they like.
- About 12 main story missions (4 per act), plus 3 to 5 side missions per region.

The relic's voice

- Speaks at key moments, gives advice and hands out some quests.
- Every line is written twice, surface meaning and true meaning: about 80 to 100 lines in total.
- The final cutscene replays 10 to 15 of the most important lines with their true meaning revealed.

The sacrifice

- The relic demands "someone who loves you": anyone whose opinion of you is +60 or higher, such as the spouse, a loyal lord or a devoted colonist.
- **Mass sacrifice** is always an option: 30% of your people, chosen at random. A ruler nobody loves has only this choice.
- The player chooses but can't refuse.
- A single sacrifice carries the -40 morality weight, and everyone close to the victim reacts. Mass sacrifice can take anyone except the hero and unkillable characters, lords and the spouse included, and carries -60, the darkest act in the game.

Relics

- The main relic plus 8 to 12 found relics, each with its own research tree and building. Some are optional and hidden.
- Most relics require bad or strange things.

Foreshadowing

Small hints a careful player can notice the first time and recognize on a second playthrough:

- Colonists feel uneasy near the relic; animals avoid it.
- A relic researcher's morality darkens.
- Rarely, a relic line flickers to its true text for a split second.

Events

A storyteller fires an event every 2 to 4 days, tuned by difficulty, balancing good and bad.

Type	Examples
Good	A wanderer joins, a trader arrives, a bountiful harvest, an inspiration
Bad	A raid, fire, plague, crop blight, a crime spree
Social	A wedding, a brawl, a bloc demand, a birth, a death

- One storyteller, tuned by difficulty.
- **Event chains:** some events unfold in steps with choices. Example: a plague starts; quarantine the sick (safer, angers families) or keep working (spreads faster); a cure is found but needs a rare herb from a bandit outpost.
- **While you're away:** never attacks or raids. Fires, disease, crime, social events, births and deaths can happen, and the colony handles them on its own.

The away report

- Grouped by category: crime, people, production, events.
- Highlights anything you might have handled differently.
- A warden's decision made within the last day can be overruled, at the usual cost to the warden's opinion of you.

The ending

- After winning the final battle, every human in your kingdom is Emptied, not just the hero.
- Non-humans suffer too: demons run on soul energy and die outright; vampires and every other non-demon creature, together called the Cursed, are already soulless and become mindless, blood-hungry creatures.
- Epilogue cards then show what became of the colony, each faction, key lords and the blocs, based on your choices: one ending, a different aftermath every time.
- The game ends there, with no continued play.

Overworld and missions

The overworld is a set of regions behind varied traversal gates, where travel is an instant transaction that costs supplies and time, and every point of interest offers something lasting. Status: first pass complete.

Regions and gates

- Regions are gated in varied ways: distance that needs better transport, the sea, a magic barrier, and so on.

Region	Gate
Home lands	None
Human heartland (pure human kingdom)	None (roads)
Creature wilds (Cursed kingdom and its sub-factions)	Distance: needs better transport
Demon wastes (demon kingdom and its sub-factions)	Magic barrier
Across the sea	Water crossing
The mountains	Climbing gear

Points of interest

Every small point of interest offers a long-term reward, and relics can come from any of them, even a mine.

Type	What it offers
Bandit camp	Small mission, loot, captives
Resource site	Becomes an outpost once cleared
Ruins	Relics, lore
Village	Recruits, trade, side missions
Shrine	Faith events, religion bonuses

Travel

- Travel is instant, like a transaction: pay the cost, time passes, and you arrive.
- **Cost:** each region away from home takes 2 days and 1 meal per person per day. Example: a 6-person squad two regions away pays 24 meals and 4 days each way. Better transport tech halves the days.
- **Oregon Trail-style risk:** a poorly supplied or low-skilled group sent far can suffer or die on the way. That can create a special rescue mission: send help to save a lord, or let them die. How this interacts with unkillable characters is still to be worked out.
- On arrival you get a travel report (injuries along the way and similar) and a colony report before you choose to engage.
- After the report, your action begins. You can't read the report and then move somewhere else instead.

Scouting

- From the war table you send scouts into a region, up to 3 per region.
- A scout finds one point of interest every 5 to 10 days, faster with high skill, with about a 5% risk per find of being killed or captured in dangerous regions.

Missions

- Every mission shows a threat rating comparing your force's total power (stats, gear, general levels) with the enemy's. Deadly can always be attempted.

Your power vs. theirs	Rating
Under 60%	Deadly
60–90%	Hard
90–120%	Even
Over 120%	Easy

- **Small missions:** a general plus 4 to 8 colonist soldiers. Objectives: clear an area, rescue, escort, retrieve a relic, or hold a position for a set time.
- **Small RTS battles:** some points of interest are smaller, randomized RTS battles. Same rules as stronghold battles, on smaller random maps, lasting 10 to 15 minutes.

- **Dispatch missions:** 2 to 10 days. Success = 50% + the general's relevant stats and traits − the mission's difficulty. Outcomes: success, partial success or failure; failure can mean injury, capture, or death at Critical.
- **What missions bring back:** resources, slaves and people who want to join. Willing recruits go through your immigration rules like anyone else; captives go straight to your captive laws.

Religion

Seven faiths, each with real pros and cons; the ruler's faith becomes the kingdom's. Status: first pass complete (faiths redefined October 22).

Faiths

Seven faiths (changed October 22): four inspired by real human religions under new names, and three unique ones. The unique faiths keep the pros and cons of the earlier Infernal, Night and relic cult faiths.

Faith	Inspired by	Core idea	Pro	Con
The Radiant Church	Medieval Catholic Church, crusade era	One true light; unbelievers must be brought to it	Holy war: +15% morale and damage against enemies of other faiths; charity houses heal faster	Intolerant: other faiths in the colony take -10 opinion; periodically demands a crusade, and refusing angers followers
The Hungering Sun	Maya and other Mesoamerican faiths	The sun must be fed with blood, or the world ends	Sacrifices give blessings: bountiful harvests, victory buffs, storms held off	Every sacrifice is a dark act; most other faiths are horrified

Faith	Inspired by	Core idea	Pro	Con
The Still Path	Buddhism	Peace through letting go of desire	Mental break chance halved; lower greed across the colony	Followers fight at -10% and dislike being drafted
The Old Halls	Norse faith	Glory in battle, honor to the fallen	Followers lose half as much morale in battle and rarely develop trauma; heroic deaths give the colony a morale boost	More brawls; followers grow restless during long peace
Demon faith	Unique	Pain is power, strength rules	Suffering builds faster, +10% combat damage	Raises crime
Cursed faith	Unique	The hunt, blood, the moon	Faster blood production, night work bonus	Unsettles humans
Cosmic faith	Unique; the relic cult	Devotion to the "voice" of the being that manipulates everyone; spreads on its own once 3 or more relics are researched, and its followers serve the entity without knowing it	Faster relic research; followers never break over dark acts	Their opinion of you depends on obeying the relic

Worship

- Buildings: shrine, then temple, then cathedral, each with a priest job slot.
- Most have requirements that fit the faith rather than simple follower counts, such as a low colony morality rating for a demon faith temple.
- Priest skill sets how much faith need is filled and how fast others convert.

Conversion

- Colonists convert through preaching, a partner's faith, or a crisis of faith during low mood. Each has a devotion value; highly devoted people almost never convert.
- The ruler can mandate that everyone convert. Each colonist of another faith rolls once: low devotion converts; medium devotion converts with -8 mood for 10 days; high devotion refuses, then about 30% worship in secret (heresy) and 30% leave.

Conflict

- Different faiths start at -5 opinion of each other; some pairs start lower, to be set when the faiths are written.
- Holy days trigger events that lift one faith and can cause friction with others.

The kingdom's faith

- The ruler's faith is the kingdom's faith, with its buffs and debuffs.
- Choosing none means no religion buff and no religion debuff.

Banned faiths and cults

- Followers of a banned faith worship in secret; that's the heresy crime. A large banned group becomes a bloc and can riot.
- **Cults** form when 5 or more followers of a banned faith gather in secret for 10 days without being caught. They recruit quietly, raise crime and, if ignored, can stage a dark ritual event.
- The cosmic faith (the relic cult) is the most dangerous: it can form without any ban once you've researched 3 or more relics.

Captives and slavery

People taken in battles, missions and courts become prisoners you can recruit, ransom, enslave, release, execute, sacrifice or use; slaves work without wages under guard, with a hidden rebellion meter. Status: first pass complete.

Sources

- Battles, bandit camps, dispatch missions, turned-away immigrants, criminals sentenced to enslavement, caravans and markets.
- After a battle or mission you win, the after-battle math decides how many fallen enemies survive; those can be taken, limited by free prison space. Without room, you choose who to take; the rest are released or killed.

Prisoners

Option	Result
Recruit	Persuade them to join over several days
Ransom	Return them to their faction for gold and +5 standing
Enslave	Becomes a worker with no wage
Release	+5 morality weight, +3 standing with their faction
Execute	-15 morality weight
Sacrifice	For relics and demon spawning
Use	Blood source, trait transfer donor

- **Recruiting:** each prisoner has a resistance from 0 to 100. A warden or recruiter lowers it daily based on Social skill. At 0 they join as a colonist at -10 opinion of the ruler.
- **Torturer:** lowers resistance 3 times faster than persuasion and can extract information (enemy army strength, spy names, stronghold weak points). Each session carries a -10 morality weight, adds to suffering and gives the prisoner a 5% chance of dying. Recruits won by torture join at -30 opinion instead of -10.
- **Prisons:** 1 prisoner per cell, 1 guard per 4 prisoners. Bad conditions (no food, cold, overcrowding) raise escape chance and add to suffering.

- **Captured enemy lords:** sometimes among the survivors taken. Worth a large ransom (gold plus +15 standing), valuable information under torture, or a powerful recruit with traits intact. Executing one costs -25 standing with their faction.

Slaves

- Work at -25% speed, with no motivation. Need 1 guard per 5 slaves. Still have needs; harsh or fair treatment affects suffering and rebellion.
- **Slave drivers:** raise slaves' work speed from -25% to +10%. Each day under a driver, every slave has a 3% chance of an overwork injury, and rebellion builds twice as fast. A stern driver doubles the injury chance; a lax one halves it.
- **Rebellion:** a hidden meter rising with harsh treatment, too few guards, and slaves above 25% of the colony. High levels bring escapes; the maximum brings a revolt that erupts into a fight.
- **Freeing:** +15 morality weight. The freed person becomes a colonist at +20 opinion of the ruler, and some feel lasting gratitude.
- **Backfire:** each slave has a hidden trait that freeing reveals. About 10% have a dangerous one (Psychopath, Vengeful, Arsonist) and are likely to commit a serious crime within 20 days. The detective, or a long stay in the colony, can reveal it beforehand.

Market and private owners

- With Slavery: Legal, you can build a slave market. Base price 100 gold per slave, adjusted by skills and race.
- Private owners pay the slave tax you set and cover their slaves' needs. Badly treated private slaves can still fuel a colony-wide revolt.

Hero

The hero is a lord in every way except where noted here: a longer level cap, Warcraft 3-style abilities, a relic slot, and the job of being King or Queen. Status: first pass complete.

Creation

- Name, prince or princess, and appearance from the Synty modular parts (skin, face, hair, body, scars, tattoos). No voice choice while the game is text-only.

- **Perks:** pick up to 3 from a list. Each perk carries its own built-in negative. Picking none is allowed.

Progression

- Levels 1 to 30, on the same XP curve as lords.
- Base stats 1.5 times a lord's: strong enough to turn a fight, not to win a battle alone.
- **Abilities:** 3 basic abilities with 3 ranks each, plus 1 ultimate at level 10; a rank is chosen at each level-up. New abilities come from race research and relics and are swapped in at the keep.

Gear

- Weapon, armor, 4 trinket slots and 1 relic slot.
- The hero can equip special gear crafted for them.
- **Relic slot:** the equipped relic gives a strong active or passive power. Swapping takes a day at the keep, and some relics punish removal with a morale hit or a nightmare event.

Equipment for everyone

- Master buildings at the colony, such as a barracks, are where units are outfitted with armor, a weapon and miscellaneous items (health boosts and similar).
- **Classes** match unit tags: infantry, ranged, cavalry, magic, siege. A lord's class comes from their unit trait (the retired archer is ranged); lords without one are infantry. Units and lords can equip only items for their class.
- Armor changes a character's appearance.
- Each master building holds a loadout template per unit type, such as "spearman: iron spear, leather armor, health boost."
- **Gear stock:** 200 iron swords means at most 200 sword-armed soldiers. Soldiers keep their gear and lose it only if they die or are captured; when stock runs out, new soldiers get basic gear.
- Loadouts carry into RTS battles and can't be changed there.

Who	Slots
Units	Weapon, armor, 1 misc

Who	Slots
Lords	Weapon, armor, 2 misc
Hero	Weapon, armor, 4 trinkets, 1 relic

The hero's role at home

- The hero can't take a job: their job is ruling.
- While the hero is home and healthy, all colonists get +5% productivity (the mirror of -15% when the hero is down).
- The ruler sets policies and can praise people or shops, each target once every 10 days. Praising a person gives them +10 mood for 3 days and +5 opinion of the ruler; praising someone others dislike can cause envy. Praising a shop gives +15% customers for 5 days.

Colony building

The colony is built Age of Empires-style: whole buildings placed freely on a large map with ground height, homes on plots the King draws, and a keep that grows room by room. Battles have no buildings; claimed keeps get a smaller, limited version of this. Status: first pass complete.

Placement and map

- Free placement, no grid, with ground height.
- Every building leaves enough space for most units to pass.
- Each building's largest upgrade footprint is reserved from the start, so upgrades never overlap.
- The map is large enough for real freedom: small towns or distant areas that take time to reach.

Construction and quality

- You place a building, haulers bring materials, builders put it up. Build time depends on size and Construction skill.

Quality	Effect
Poor	-15% output or comfort, lower durability
Normal	Standard
Good	+10%
Excellent	+20%
Masterwork	+30%, and colonists admire it

- Buildings upgrade in place through tiers (a hut becomes a workshop, then a forge), keeping their staff.
- Buildings lose durability and are repaired automatically through work priorities, but never drop below 50% health from wear.

Zones

- The King places all zones: residential (low, middle, high), commercial, industrial, farm and government.
- The King draws squares for residential plots; they look like a grid. Each plot is larger than the house, the owner picks the rotation, and leftover space fills with random details so homes look unique.

The keep

- Works like XCOM: you add rooms to it, within limits.
- About 8 room slots: throne room (required), war room (required, formerly the war table), treasury, armory, study, chapel, dungeon and relic vault. Upgrades add 2 more.

Unique buildings

- Placed only by the ruler, and limited: the keep, each race's embassy, each relic building, the slave market and similar.

Military buildings

- One master building per class, each holding loadout templates and training colony soldiers:

Class	Master building
Infantry	Hall of Blades
Ranged	Range of Arrows
Cavalry	The Stables
Magic	Arcane Sanctum
Siege	The Siegeworks

- **Barracks** are where soldiers live, separate from residential zones. Soldiers there count as housed, and barracks quality affects their mood.

Defenses

- Walls, gates and towers, from wood to stone to reinforced, exist only at the colony.

Building staffing

Every colony building has up to 3 job slots, and who fills them decides how well it runs. Status: started during the generals discussion; details to come with the jobs system.

- Slots are distinct roles, such as worker, manager and trainer.
- Anyone can fill any slot, but poor stats in that field hurt the building's output.
- **Foremen:** the King or Queen can promote someone to foreman and give a staffing policy, such as always placing the best available unassigned person, or placing average people.